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On Friday 4 June, WCPMC met with the Director of the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases Dr. Anthony Fauci to present our analysis on the COVID origins topic as well as our approach to the intelligence question.

Dr. Fauci was particularly interested in the WIV's work on pangolins and asked for specifics on the type of experiments the Chinese were conducting on pangolin samples in the fall of 2019. He keyed in on specifics about Vero cell passaging and experiments on transgenic mice. He did not appear to be aware of a coronavirus outbreak among pangolins in a specific region in southern China in 2019 or the fact that WIV had obtained samples from these animals.

He highlighted the importance of getting samples from the individuals at WIV who were ill in the fall of 2019. He encouraged the IC to examine their medical records and seek blood samples to perform serology tests to determine whether there was evidence of prior COVID-19 infection. Dr. Fauci wondered aloud whether the USG had formally made this request to China in diplomatic or public health channels.

Dr. Fauci and CIA experts agreed on the importance of understanding whether SARS COV-2 originated from single or multiple viral lineages. He encouraged CIA to contact Tulane professor and virologist Dr. Robert Garry who noted in a recent publication that the Joint WHO-China team identified two clades of SARS COV-2 in people that visited two different wet markets in China, a finding that we are currently evaluating with CIA SMEs and NCPC's Biological Sciences Expert Group. He also directed CIA to Scripps Institute researcher Dr. Kristian Andersen who has done innovative modeling and other work on the origin of the COVID-19 pandemic. Dr. Fauci also suggested the IC connect with Australian researcher Ed Holmes, all three of whom have advocated for features of the virus that they judge to be consistent with a natural origin.

Dr. Fauci expressed concern about Beijing's quick and thorough cleaning of the Huanan Seafood Market. He noted that Beijing may have made a serious epidemiological misstep that could have destroyed key clues as to how the pandemic began. He offered his opinion that the Chinese have shown they are better scientists than epidemiologists. In Dr. Fauci's view, it is not surprising that Chinese have not found evidence of a zoonotic transfer or an intermediate host of the virus, because the search for natural reservoir of the SARS virus took over a decade, and in the case of some strains of Ebolavirus, still has not been found. If the virus jumped to humans from an animal reservoir, he said it would be like "searching for a needle in a haystack."

